Heidi

A simplified retelling

Original story by Johanna Spyri

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. Up the mountain

When Heidi was five, her aunt Dete took her up a Swiss mountain to live with her grandfather. Dete had cared for her since her parents died, but now she had found work elsewhere.

The villagers regarded the old man with suspicion. He lived apart from them and could be sharp with visitors. Heidi, however, was interested in his house, the goats and the wide view. She asked questions without fear.

Her grandfather made her a bed in the loft, where she could see the stars. He prepared food, and she watched him work. His life, which had become very quiet, now included a child who found almost everything worth noticing.

Heidi went out with Peter, the boy who looked after the goats. She learned their names and grew to love the mountain pasture. The wind, the flowers and the changing light became part of her happiness.

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2. A grandmother in the village

During the winter, Heidi visited Peter’s mother and his blind grandmother. Their house was old and shook in the wind. The grandmother loved hearing Heidi’s cheerful voice.

Heidi wished she could help her see again. When she understood that she could not, she looked for smaller things she might do. Her grandfather repaired parts of the house, encouraged by Heidi’s concern.

The village pastor wanted Heidi to attend school. Her grandfather resisted, unwilling to return to village life or to accept advice. Heidi did not understand all the old disagreements around him. She knew only that the people she loved were not as separate as they first appeared.

Then Aunt Dete returned. She had arranged for Heidi to become a companion to a girl in Frankfurt. The family was wealthy, and Dete believed this would provide a better future.

Heidi’s grandfather objected. But Dete took the child away, promising that she could return.

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3. Clara’s house

In Frankfurt, Heidi met Clara Sesemann, who used a wheelchair and lived in a large house. Clara’s father travelled often. The household was managed by Miss Rottenmeier, who expected strict manners.

Clara liked Heidi immediately. Heidi brought unexpected questions and stories into a carefully organised life. But the city confused her. Windows did not open onto mountains, and going outside was no longer simple.

Miss Rottenmeier was often impatient with her. Heidi could not read, did not know the household rules and sometimes misunderstood what was expected. She hid soft bread rolls because she wanted to take them to Peter’s grandmother.

Clara’s grandmother visited and treated her more patiently. With encouragement, Heidi began learning to read. Stories gave her another kind of company. Yet every new skill existed alongside a growing ache for home.

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4. A house that seemed haunted

Heidi tried not to complain. She had been told that speaking about leaving would upset Clara. At night, however, she dreamed of the mountain and woke in distress.

Strange things began happening. Doors were found open, and a white figure was seen moving through the house. The servants thought there might be a ghost.

The doctor and Mr Sesemann investigated. The figure was Heidi, walking in her sleep. She was trying to get home without knowing what she was doing.

The doctor recognised how unhappy she had become and advised that she return to her grandfather. Mr Sesemann agreed. Clara was sad to lose her companion, but her father understood that keeping Heidi there was damaging her health.

Heidi travelled back with gifts and new abilities. Her happiness when she saw the mountain was too large for careful manners. She ran towards the home she had been afraid of never seeing again.

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5. Returning with something to share

Her grandfather welcomed her warmly. The reunion changed him too. His affection for Heidi had become more important than his determination to remain apart from everyone.

Heidi visited Peter’s grandmother and read to her. The older woman could not see the words, but she could hear them. Heidi had returned with a way to give pleasure that had not existed before she left.

Her grandfather began rebuilding his connection with the village. In winter, they moved down to a house where Heidi could attend school. She encouraged Peter to practise reading too, although he would rather have avoided it.

The Frankfurt doctor visited and found comfort in the mountain and in Heidi’s friendship. Later, Clara came with her grandmother. Heidi was delighted to show her the places she had described so often.

For Clara, the mountain was a new experience. Fresh air, food, rest and gentle activity gradually helped her grow stronger.

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6. Peter’s mistake

Peter was jealous. Clara’s visit meant that he had less of Heidi’s attention. In anger, he pushed Clara’s empty wheelchair down the mountain, where it broke.

He did not tell anyone what he had done. His secret made him anxious, especially when adults began asking questions.

Without the chair, Clara needed more help moving around. Heidi’s grandfather supported her carefully. With encouragement and practice, she discovered that she could stand and begin to walk. Her progress was gradual, not something she could simply have chosen earlier.

When Clara’s family returned, they were astonished and delighted to see her take steps. Peter feared punishment for destroying the chair. Clara’s grandmother helped him admit his fault and understand its seriousness without treating him as beyond forgiveness.

The families made plans for future visits and for Heidi’s security. She would not be abandoned if her grandfather could no longer care for her.

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Heidi had once arrived on the mountain with almost nothing. Now she belonged to a circle of people who had learned to care for one another across very different lives.

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Words to keep

Pasture — land where animals feed on grass. Peter took the goats to the pasture.

Companion — someone who spends time with another person. Heidi became Clara’s companion.

Homesick — unhappy because you miss your home. Heidi became deeply homesick in Frankfurt.

Encouragement — support that helps someone attempt something. Patient encouragement helped Heidi learn to read.

Jealous — upset because someone else receives something you want. Peter was jealous of Clara’s time with Heidi.

Security — the feeling of being safe and provided for. The family’s plans gave Heidi security.

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A question to carry with you

How can a place be comfortable and well provided for, yet still fail to feel like home to someone?

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